Outline of the Dissertation regulations

March 30, 2026

Your *Dissertation Module* will take the form of an individual project in some aspect of Scientific Computing or Scientific Data Analysis. For this project you will be assigned a supervisor with whom you will have regular meetings. Please keep logs (minutes) of every single meeting including action items. Please stick exactly to all formats required.

1 Formative Assessments

The *formative* assessments are submissions for which you will receive feedback but no mark from your supervisor. The following two submissions are due at the end of the **1st week** after the Easter Break, i.e. by **1 May 2026**, and have to be submitted using the corresponding submission link on the Ultra page of MiSCADA projects (alternatively you could submit it directly to your supervisor by email, if your supervisor agrees). The supervisor will give you feedback on these formative assessments within one week.

Important Note: Although the following formative assessments are not marked, they can influence the "supervisor mark" (which is the mark that your supervisor will give you at the end after their experience with you during the supervision period).

1.1 Ethical Assessment Form (only for some projects)

This is a formative submission for only some projects. Every student must discuss any possible **ethical considerations** of their project with the supervisor, for example issues related to human participants, access to data, non-disclosure agreements, etc. For **some (but not necessarily all) projects**, an **Ethical Assessment Form** has to be submitted, using the following link:
`https://durhamuniversity.sharepoint.com/teams/researchoffice/ethics/Pages/COMP.aspx`

In some cases (e.g. when gathering sensitive data from human participants), the student might also need to create additional documents for the parties involved (e.g. consent form, privacy notice, participant leaflet).

Furthermore, the student must always adhere to the University's Intellectual Property Policy, which can be found here:
`https://www.dur.ac.uk/research.innovation/local/governance/policy/ip/`

1.2 Risk Assessment (only for some projects)

Every student must discuss with the supervisor whether a **Risk Assessment** is needed for their project. It is expected that many projects in the **Computer Vision / Robotics** stream will need such a risk assessment, while other projects may not need it. Some guidelines on how to prepare a Risk assessment can be found on the Ultra page of MiSCADA projects, but your supervisor can give you more detailed advice on that.

2 Literature review and project plan (for all projects)

This is a *summative* submission for every project. That is, you will get a mark by your supervisor for your Literature Review and Project Plan, and this mark is worth 15% of your total MiSCADA project mark. We ask for this to ensure that work is progressing in a timely manner; your supervisor will give you feedback on your progress as well as suggestions for improvement. Your report should be **no more than 8 pages** and should discuss the following items:

- What is scientific background, i.e. the context of the project?
- Which are the anticipated outcomes of the project? You are strongly advised to break down the outcomes into basic, intermediate and advanced goals, and that you clarify how risky/difficult they are.
- What is your research question?
- What is your project time plan? Please include a Gantt chart.
- How will you demonstrate success? That is, what kind of tests will you conduct to show that your project is correct, robust, and performing as intended? (You can compare with assessment criteria for your summative submission, see below).

3 Project report (Dissertation)

The project report is also *summative*, and it will be marked by your supervisor and by another independent examiner. This mark is worth 75% of your total MiSCADA project mark. The remaining 10% of your total MiSCADA project mark will be given by your supervisor as the "supervisor mark". The project report should conform to the general structure (with the four main elements) outlined below. However, we intentionally **do not provide a strict template**. You should read a few proper papers in the field of your dissertation (these could be the latest papers suggested by your supervisor) and you should distill how to structure a report from these papers within this field. In any case, **you need to agree with your supervisor** on what is the **appropriate template** to follow in your dissertation report. What you submit should look and feel like a real journal or conference paper in the corresponding scientific area – even though it obviously follows lower standards than a real scientific paper.

The project report should consist of these four main elements:

1. A title and preamble, containing the names of the student and supervisor, the degree programme (together with the words "MSc Dissertation") and the academic year.
2. The abstract. This should be in form commensurate with a suitably relevant conference or journal and will typically be around half a page in length.
3. The main body. This will consist of a set of sections as specified in Section 3.3.1. The student must discuss and agree the specific format of your paper with their supervisor. The appropriate format should ideally be in the format of a scientific journal that is related to the topic of the project. Moreover:

- For **Computer Vision / Robotics projects:** at most **8 pages** long (double column) in the ICRA/IROS conference template (excluding bibliography).
  The template to use is the IEEE conference one which is here:
  `https://www.ieee.org/conferences/publishing/templates.html`,
  or here in overleaf:
  `https://www.overleaf.com/latex/templates/ieee-conference-template/grfzhhncsfqn`
- For **all other projects:** The paper must be in the appropriate format (for the field of study) and it must be **no more than 20 pages** long, **excluding bibliography (i.e. references)**. We ask for a font size **no smaller than 11pt** with **at least 2cm of margin** on all sides.

IMPORTANT NOTE: You must agree with your supervisor which is the appropriate format for your particular project, but the above guidelines must be followed.

4. The references. These should be either in Harvard format (author, date) or in Vancouver format (numeric, with citations in numeric square brackets). The number of references will obviously depend upon the nature of the project, but we would normally expect a minimum of 10 academic references. Where possible, you should avoid using references to web sites, and if this is necessary, should ensure that they are correctly cited.

It is particularly important that you note the length requirement for your particular project (which you need to agree with your supervisor in advance). In fact, only the first 20 pages (or only the first 8 pages if your paper is formatted in the ICRA/IROS conference template) will be taken into consideration when marking the project report.

3.1 Submission

The project report is due on **4 September 2026** at **2:00pm** and is to be submitted on Learn Ultra. The submission should consist of the following items:

1. The **project report in pdf format**; its content should be **no more than 20 pages** in length (or **no more than 8 pages** in length if it is formatted in the **ICRA/IROS conference template**), excluding references and an optional Appendix (it is expected that most projects will have no Appendix at all).
2. Your **project code.** This can be submitted in one of the following two different ways:
   (a) **First way:** Upload on Learn Ultra a **zipped file** containing **all your code (and possibly datasets)**.
   (b) **Second way:** Submit a single .txt file which contains only the link to a *Zenodo* archive of your code and your data. If you manage your code in a GitHub repository, please follow the instructions for creating citeable code (`https://guides.github.com/activities/citable-code`).
3. Your **project log.** This contains (in a zipped file) all the notes (dated if possible) that you were keeping about your progress during the dissertation. This could for example include questions you had and how you answered them after a meeting with your supervisor, or after reading some online material, or after solving by yourself a problem you had, etc. Your project log does not have any pre-specified format, it just consists of all your notes and material you generated during your work and preparation for the dissertation project.

3.1.1 Submission extensions

Students can submit requests for an extension using the corresponding submission form which can be found here:

https://durhamuniversity.sharepoint.com/teams/ComputerScienceUndergraduateCommunity/SitePages/Coursework-Deadline-Extensions.aspx

If the project report is submitted later than 5 weeks prior to the final Board of Examiners (e.g. due to a long extension which has been requested and granted), the mark of the Miscada project will normally not be considered at the final Board of Examiners. Instead, it will be normally dealt with either with Chair's action or in the following Board of Examiners meeting.

3.2 Assessment criteria for the Dissertation

A major objective of the project is to allow you to exercise the skills, knowledge, practices, and critical thinking skills acquired in the taught modules. Therefore top priority must be given to establishing the academic context of the project, and showing how your work relates to other work in the chosen field. The individual nature of projects means that each one will need to be assessed using different criteria. Masters projects are not research projects. There is no obligation (as it is in a PhD) to produce original outcomes. In addition, the product element of a project does not need to produce "successful" results when exploring some idea; assessment is based upon the processes that you have followed, not the outcomes. A project that competently demonstrates that an idea is not feasible (and the reasons why) is every bit as valuable a contribution to knowledge as one that does: in this case, a "negative result" is still a result! Assessment of project work involves the supervisor, another member of staff, and the External Examiner. Any differences that may arise between marks awarded by the various examiners will be investigated and resolved with care, and all marks will need to be approved by the MSc Board of Examiners.

3.3 How the Dissertation mark is computed

The mark for the Dissertation module has three main parts:

- The mark for the **Literature Review and Project Plan** counts towards **15%** of the Project mark.
- The mark for the written **Project Report** counts towards **75%** of the Project mark.
- The remaining **10%** of the Project mark is given by the **Supervisor mark**. The Supervisor mark is based on the experience that your supervisor got with you during the supervision period. Recall that the formative assessments (although they are not directly marked) can influence the Supervisor mark.

3.3.1 Details about the mark for the written Project Report

The written Project Report will be marked using the following allocation of marks.

1. Abstract, Introduction, and Conclusion (20%):
   - The abstract has to provide a clear summary of the key points from your paper, be capable of being used as a "stand-alone" description of the project report.
   - The introduction has to clearly present the rationale for undertaking this particular study and the question(s) that it is seeking to answer. It should also discuss the aims and achievements of the project.
   - The conclusion should discuss the outcomes and link them to the initial question, together with any recommendations for further work.
2. Related Work (20%). This section should demonstrate:
   - Knowledge of the relevant literature and research findings, demonstrating their influence upon the approach taken.
   - A clear strategy for finding that information.

- Critical analysis of the literature, ideally also comparing different approaches to each other in the literature.

3. Solution and Results (50%): Note that this is not necessarily a section of your project report. As described above, the sections have to be appropriately designed in a way that makes sense to your individual topic and in a way that makes sense in the particular field of your dissertation. In this part (which might consist of various different sections, depending on your field). we are looking for evidence of:

   - Adequacy of the adopted/proposed "solution" (architecture/design).
   - Problem-solving ability.
   - Explanation of a rationale for specific design/strategy choices.
   - Clarity and adequacy of the description of the presented results.
   - Clarity of the distinction between literature and own results/contribution.
   - Description of the algorithms used (if applicable).
   - Discussion of implementation issues encountered (if applicable).
   - Description of the tools used (technical and/or theoretical tools).
   - Specification and design (if applicable).
   - Verification and Validation (if applicable).
   - Description of the evaluation method adopted (if applicable).
   - Discussion of, and outcomes from, your testing strategy (if applicable).
   - The evaluation strategy adopted and its suitability for your task.
   - Assessment of any limitations upon conclusions.
   - Identification of any threats to validity of the outcomes (if applicable).

4. Writing Skills (10%):

   - Clarity of presentation of ideas.
   - Quality of writing (readability, grammar).
   - Conformance to a format suitable for a research paper in the field of the project.

Appropriate implementation details, such as parts of source code or circuit diagrams, should normally be included as a **clearly marked Appendix**, together with indications of sample runs. Project reports must be backed up with experimentation, implementation, theoretical or conceptual analysis, new illustrative examples, and so on.

3.3.2 Details about the Supervisor mark

This is the mark that your supervisor gives, based on their interaction they had with you throughout the project. More specifically, the Supervisor mark will be given according to the following criteria:

- Identification of the important project management considerations.
- Ability to justify project management approaches adopted and analysis of their successfulness.
- Application of planning and conformance to plan.
- Application of leadership / direction throughout the project.
- Demonstration of problem solving ability.
- If applicable to your project:
  - Appropriate demonstration of software and/or technical solution

  - Appropriate risk assessment and ethics approval process followed

IMPORTANT: Please note that the scheduled meetings with the supervisor (as described in the Dissertation module page on Learn Ultra) are **mandatory**, and that these meetings can feed into the Supervisor mark.

The Dissertation mark (i.e. the overall mark of the module) is given one of the following grades when awarded marks in the indicated ranges:

- 70-100: D (Distinction)
- 60-69: M (Merit)
- 50-59: P (Pass)
- 0-49: F (Fail)

A detailed description of each of the above mark ranges can be found in the separate table for the MSc assessment criteria for the Dissertation.

The project timeline is as follows:

Before the end of Term 1:

- From the end of week 4 and until the **end of week 5 (including the weekend)**, i.e. from Friday 31 October until **Monday 10 November 2025 9:00am**, you will be able to submit your project preferences in the online submission system here: https://cssystems.awh.durham.ac.uk/password/projects/student/
- In the above submission system, you will be able to submit **up to 6 different projects** and **up to 1 project per supervisor**.
- This restriction (i.e. one project per supervisor) **does not apply** to the **industry co-supervised projects**.
- The allocation of projects and students to supervisors will be **announced at the beginning of Term 2.** The allocation will be done by talking into account the student preferences and any agreements between academics and students (potentially also including a company as a partner) about specific project topics.
- It is expected that several project students will be allocated to the same supervisor and to the same "project theme". The scope of these project themes will be broad enough to cover the specific topics of all students who are allocated to the theme. As such, it is expected that many of the project meetings (see below) will be group meetings between the supervisor and the students of a specific theme. During these group meetings, the students will be able to benefit from their interaction with the supervisor and with the other students. Nevertheless, there will be some projects that will only be allocated 1 student due to the nature of the project; this can happen for example for some projects of the Computer Vision / Robotics stream, where the student needs a specific piece of equipment for the project.
- **IMPORTANT:** The MISCADA projects are **NOT collaborative**. Although two or more students can work within the same "theme", the exact topic of the project will be different. More specifically, each student is required to work alone on his/her own individual project topic (as agreed with the supervisor), and to eventually submit their own work in September. Nevertheless, the students can mutually benefit from the interaction with the other students who are working on similar specific topic within the same theme.

During Term 2 and in the Easter Break:

- Students will have in **Term 2** in total **4 initial preparatory meetings** with their supervisors. In these meetings the supervisors will discuss with the students their intended project, its deliverables, the necessary background knowledge, the previous literature etc.
- The first of these four initial meetings will take place immediately after the Miscada project allocation is announced at the beginning of Term 2, and the remaining three meetings will be scheduled at appropriate times that will be agreed between the supervisors and the students. In these meetings the supervisor will give general instructions on how the student can prepare for the

project, do background reading and **start working alone during Term 2 and during the Easter Break**, such that the student is fully prepared for the core dissertation period, which starts immediately after the Easter Break.

- During Term 2 and in the Easter Break, the students will work towards preparing their **Literature Review** and their **Project Plan**.
- The supervisor is expected to give the student feedback on their progress (and suggestions for improvement) while the student prepares the Literature Review and Project Plan. It is expected that this feedback will be given during the 4 preparatory meetings in Term 2, and potentially also on a draft that the student sends to the supervisor shortly before the submission.

During Term 3:

- During the **first week after the Easter Break**, the students will submit their prepared **Literature Review** and **Project Plan**, which are summatively assessed (15% of the Project module mark).
- Starting from the **beginning of Term 3** (i.e. in week 21), the students are expected to work on their project for 6-9 weeks in a row on the **core dissertation phase** (the research phase).
- It is the **responsibility of the student to contact their supervisor** and to **arrange these weekly meetings with them**, starting at the first week after the Easter Break.
- During this core dissertation phase:
    - **The students must engage with their project** and **meet with their supervisor weekly.**
    - **Participation** in these meetings is **mandatory.**
    - It is the **responsibility of the student to arrange weekly meetings with their supervisors during the core dissertation phase.**
- Students are expected to be in Durham in Term 3.
- Students must attend the pre-scheduled project meetings with their supervisor, and they have to **make notes / take minutes** from these meetings.
    - These notes have to be uploaded by the students on the following dedicated website (which is very easy to use):
    - cssystems.awh.durham.ac.uk/password/projectreporting/index.php
    - These notes do not have to be very detailed or very formal, they just need to briefly describe/outline the content of the meeting. Alternatively, if the webpage is not working for some reason, the students will have to send their notes/minutes to their supervisor by email**.**
- After the end of the core dissertation phase, students will have two months **(July / August)** to finalize their work and to write-up of their work in the form of a project report, which they will submit in the beginning of September.
- During this write-up phase (in July/August), the students have to give to the supervisor a preliminary draft of their project report to get feedback from them. This preliminary draft does not need to be a complete project report, it can just be some chapter(s). After that, there will be a **mandatory meeting** in which the feedback of the supervisor will be discussed. It is the student's responsibility give this draft to the supervisor early enough, to allow sufficient time to them for reading the draft (e.g. one week), and to arrange with the supervisor the

exact time of the meeting. The recommended time for this meeting is at the end of July or at most the first week of August.

Specific milestones:

- In the **middle or end of May**, the student must perform a preliminary **demonstration of all the results** so far to the supervisor. This process is formative (i.e. no mark will be given) but the supervisor will give feedback (either oral or written, as appropriate) to the student within one week about the progress made so far.
- Every student must discuss any possible **ethical considerations** of their project with the supervisor, for example issues related to human participants, access to data, non-disclosure agreements, etc. For some (but not necessarily all) projects, an **Ethical Assessment Form** has to be submitted. You can find below an exact description of how to prepare and submit this Ethical Assessment Form.
- Every student must discuss with the supervisor whether a **risk assessment** is needed for the project. It is expected that many projects in the Computer Vision / Robotics stream will need such a risk assessment, while other projects may not need it. You can find below an exact description of how to prepare and submit this Risk Assessment Form.
- During the **1st week** after the Easter Break, i.e. **by 1 May 2026**, the student needs to submit the following:

    1. a **Literature review and Project plan**, which should be in total **no more than 8 pages**,

    2. the **Ethical Assessment** form (if needed for the particular project), and

    3. the **Risk Assessment** form (if needed for the particular project).

    The Literature Review and Project Plan is a summative assessment (15% of the total mark), but the Ethical and Risk Assessments (if applicable) are formative assessment (i.e. no mark will be given) but the supervisor will give feedback to the student within one week.

    Important note: Although the Ethical and Risk Assessments (if applicable) are not marked, they can influence the "supervisor mark" (which is the mark that the supervisor gives at the end after their experience with the student during the supervision period).

- By **4 September 2026** at **2pm** the student needs to submit the **Project Report (Dissertation)**, together with their **program code** and their **project log**.
- For a detailed description of the formative and summative assessments and for the Project Report, the program code and the project log, see the **Dissertation regulations** document **(attached)**.

For industry co-supervised projects:

- The project supervision meetings can be either virtual or in person.
- Students can either work at the partner's institution (if appropriate) or in Durham with remote supervision. Industry partners are not expected to cover for student travel and support. It is thus not required that students physically join the industry partner.
- The academic supervisor has to be kept in the loop about the project progress (meeting minutes).

Key notes:

- Students will have 4 preparatory meetings with their supervisor during Term 2.
- During Term 2 and the Easter Break the students will do all necessary background reading and preparation for their project, and they will prepare the Literature Review and Project plan (which will be submitted by 1 May 2026).
- The core dissertation time is from 27 April - 26 June 2026.
- Typically, students work for 6-9 weeks on the core dissertation and use the remaining time for write-ups and presentations.
- Final submission for report (as well as the project code and log book) is 4 September 2026 at 2pm.
- You (i.e. the student) are responsible to organize your time and to agree with your supervisor team on well-suited periods when you work on which part (create a project plan/Gantt chart).
- See the Ultra module page and the level handbook for all submission deadlines.

Finally, **attached** you can find **two indicative templates** for the final report, one in Latex and one in Word. Note that these are **not strict templates** and they **do not apply to all projects**. The appropriate format of the final report may significantly deviate for some projects (e.g. for many projects in the Computer Vision / Robotics stream).

Important: For a guide on how to choose a particular template for your dissertation please read carefully the **Dissertation regulations** and also consult with your supervisor.

Important: Please be very careful about **plagiarism and collusion**, as these incidents are taken very seriously in the university and marks will be lost when plagiarism or collusion occurs in the dissertation. Therefore, please give proper reference to the sources you use material from. For more information, please read further here:

https://libguides.durham.ac.uk/research_skills/managing_info/plagiarism

https://durhamuniversity.sharepoint.com/teams/LTH/SitePages/6.2.4.aspx